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198R-Retail Management Internship

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Store Executive Intern at Target

Introduction:

As a Store Executive Intern at Target Corporation, I gained hands-on experience in both store operations and Human Resources. I worked full-time-40 hours a week, 5 days a week for 8 weeks, rotating through all departments. In the end, I specialized in Specialty Sales, which includes home, decor, beauty, and apparel and also Human Resources. In Specialty Sales, I co-led a team of over 30 members to ensure merchandise was consistently stocked on the sales floor, visually appealing, and properly backstocked. I also collaborated with the visual merchandising team to design and execute seasonal displays that aligned with Target's brand. Additionally, I supported the store remodeling team by helping coordinate product transitions throughout the renovation process, such as the Back-to-School department that is recreated every summer. On the HR side, I focused on fostering a supportive team culture, learning that caring for and empathizing with your team is crucial to success. I also worked with talent acquisition where I reviewed applications, conducted performance check-ins, assisted with onboarding and training new hires, and learned about termination procedures. I learned how important staffing and scheduling are as well as being aware of peak rush hours in the store and high call-out days. Overall, my internship at Target provided me with valuable leadership, retail operation, and HR experiences that I will carry forward into my future career.

Key Learnings:

During my internship, I gained a deep understanding of how Target operates in the retail industry from a management perspective. Something new I learned about Target's store leadership is how it's organized into five departments-Specialty Sales, General Merchandise, Service and Engagement, Assets Protection, and Human Resources. Each leader is responsible for driving success within their department while always keeping the guest experience at the center. While these departments work together to drive success, each plays a unique role. For example, Specialty Sales manages visual merchandising, General Merchandise ensures shelves are fully stocked, Service and Engagement focuses on customer feedback, Assets Protection keeps everyone and products safe, and finally Human Resources oversees hiring and team development. Rotating through each department allowed me to observe unique leadership styles and understand how they collectively contribute to Target's operational success. I never realized the extensive management work that is required to keep a retail store running smoothly.

I also learned that small details play a significant role in drawing customers into the store and encouraging them to return. From the moment a guest walks into Target, it's essential that team members create a welcoming environment through a positive and upbeat attitude. Greeting guests promptly and warmly have become a key focus across all stores, as they set the tone for a memorable shopping experience. After concluding this internship, I now notice the store atmosphere immediately when walking into a new Target. Additionally, how the guest's experience ends is equally important and our team members at guest checkout lanes should always make them feel valued and appreciated. By creating these positive touchpoints at both the beginning and end of the shopping trip, Target strengthens its connection with customers and leaves them with a lasting, positive impression that encourages repeat visits. With so many

retailers focusing on growing their online presence nowadays, Target continues to emphasize the in-store experience, maintaining its position as a leader in brick-and-mortar retail.

Another valuable takeaway from my internship was learning how Target's brand collaborations enhance seasonal sections of their stores. For example, this year for the back-to-school season, Target partnered with Champion to launch an exclusive collection. This partnership not only attracted students shopping for Champion apparel but also encouraged them to explore other areas of the store, such as the back-to-school supplies section. The supplies section is strategically located in the far back corner of the store, encouraging guests to walk through other departments along the way and increasing the likelihood that they will make additional purchases. I witnessed many guests come in specifically for Champion items and then ask where to find school supplies before starting the school year highlighting the success of this collaboration. This also creates scarcity among shoppers, as they know the exclusive Champion collection is only available for a limited time, encouraging them to make purchases before the items are gone. I was surprised to learn how much a major retailer like Target relies on brand collaborations to drive traffic, create excitement, and enhance the overall shopping experience.

Lastly, I learned the importance of product placement, especially in Specialty Sales, in order to sell products at Target. Particularly in the apparel department, every detail is intentional, from spacing between hangers to the height of a neatly folded stack of jeans. Target invests in creating visually appealing displays that draw guests in and encourage purchases. Mirrors are strategically placed through the clothing section so guests can easily see how items might look on them. Team members are always stationed near the fitting room, especially during peak traffic hours, to offer immediate assistance. These small efforts collectively enhance the guest

experience and drive sales, making product placement a powerful tool in Target's strategy. Now, I notice all the little details when shopping that encourage me to make purchases.

What Surprised Me:

One thing that surprised me about Target was their new Flexible Retail Pricing strategy, where items no longer have individual price tags but are instead displayed under a value sign indicating their price. Currently, this pricing strategy is only in the girls' All in Motion (a Target Brand) athletic clothing section of the store. This approach is designed to help Target stand out from other retailers and quickly adjust prices in response to the changing economic environment. By simply updating the signage, Target can easily increase or decrease prices without the time and cost of re-tagging individual items. While this strategy offers efficiency and adaptability, I noticed that it also creates challenges for the Specialty Sales department in maintaining organization. I experienced this while managing my team, where we had to regularly ensure that items were under the correct value sign, which added time to our daily routines. However, if executed effectively, this strategy had the potential to be a game changer for Target's pricing strategy throughout the store. This strategy surprised me because I haven't seen it implemented in any other physical retail stores, and I'm very curious to see how it will evolve and impact Target's overall operations.

Another aspect that surprised me was the high level of cross-collaboration between departments. At first glance, each department at Target seems distinct and separate, in reality, they communicate and work together daily to drive results. For example, although each department creates its own schedules for team members, HR must approve the allocated hours and payroll. Similarly, Assets Protection partners closely with General Merchandise to protect products that have high theft rates. Rotating within each department gave me valuable insights

into these overlaps and the interdependence of their roles. Attending our weekly huddles further showed me how much departments rely on one another and reinforced the importance of teamwork in achieving store success. Before this role, I had assumed business departments operated fairly independently, but Target showed me a management style that emphasizes effective teamwork and cross-collaboration to drive results.

Lastly, I was surprised to see how much Target prioritizes employee development. Throughout my internship, I observed that leadership consistently checks in with team members to understand their career goals and aspirations. This made employees feel supported in their growth and development. Target also provides structured tools and templates for career development and advancement, making it clear what the next steps are. This emphasis on developing talent creates a culture where employees are empowered to take initiative, build new skills, and feel motivated to come into work everyday. Working in HR it was amazing to see the development of some team members over just eight weeks. Seeing a retailer so invested in the growth of its team members was both inspiring and surprising, and it showed me effective ways to foster engagement and retention in the workplace.

Applying My Internship Experience to Future Roles:

One of the biggest takeaways from my internship that I can highlight in job interviews is my growth in team management and leadership. For the last 4 weeks, I co-led the Specialty Sales and Human Resources departments along with my mentors, managing a team of over 30 members. In Specialty Sales, I created assignment sheets to delegate workloads effectively across the departments to ensure each was operating at its highest potential. I also conducted performance check-ins with team members and actively sought feedback to improve team operations. This experience allowed me to practice clear communication, adaptability, and

develop a collaborative leadership style. In interviews, I can discuss how I successfully balanced managing multiple responsibilities, motivated team members, and what I learned from retail operations.

In Human Resources, I gained hands-on experience that I can confidently bring into job interviews. I screened applications, conducted orientation sessions for new hires, and regularly checked in with team members to support their growth. This role taught me the importance of balancing empathy and compassion with achieving business goals. One of the most impactful experiences was working with my HR mentor to address a decline in store morale and workplace culture. Together, we launched initiatives such as lunch-ins to encourage team connection and coordinated volunteer events that counted as workdays, giving employees the opportunity to give back to the community while also recharging outside of work. Through these efforts, I strengthened my ability to navigate difficult situations, practice active listening, and build strong relationships. In an interview I can highlight how this experience helped me refine these skills and how I can handle difficult situations.

Insights on the EMPAC Model:

For the EMPAC Model, Target exemplifies it as a brick-and-mortar retailer, particularly with the “e” for entertainment. Target's mission is to create an engaging and enjoyable shopping experience that encourages guests to continue to visit their stores, even as the retail industry continues to shift online. In select stores, Target now offers food and beverage samples, which adds a fun and interactive element to the shopping trip. Additionally, in the technology department, guests can test out products such as iPads, iPhones, and tablets which not only entertains but also helps customers test out the product and make informed purchases. These

initiatives enhance the overall shopping experience and allow Target to grow its commitment to drawing guests in through an entertaining shopping experience.

The “M” for matching for the EMPAC Model, Target utilizes signage, visual displays, and merchandising presentations to create a visually appealing atmosphere for guests to want to shop in. During my time in specialty sales, I learned that a strong visual merchandising plan for this department was essential to success and driving sales. Every aisle and endcap was carefully planned and mapped out by my mentor and I to ensure that the space was as inviting and shoppable as possible for guests. For example, my team at Target strategically stocked endcaps with seasonal or brightly colored products to catch the attention and inspire customers to go down that aisle. The goal was always to encourage guests to leave with more than what they initially came in for. Through thoughtful and visual merchandising, Target ensures that every display not only enhances the in-store atmosphere but also inspires guests to discover and purchase more than they initially expected.

Furthermore, for ‘a’ as assortment, Target positions itself as a one-stop shop, offering everything from groceries and cleaning supplies to home decor, apparel, and pharmaceuticals. This broad mix is strengthened by partnerships that draw in more groups of guests such as Apple in technology, CVS pharmacies in select stores, Disney, and Ulta Beauty sections. Instead of customers having to go buy a new phone case at Apple, pick up their prescription at an urgent care, and pick up a new mascara all can be done at your local Target. Additionally, Target has developed more than 40 private-label brands, including All in Motion, Good & Gather, and Up&Up. These brands are strategically placed next to competitors to emphasize price advantages while allowing guests to distinguish quality for themselves. The private labels are also an

opportunity to build customer loyalty and reinforce Target's reputation for convenience, value, and variety all in one place.

As for price, "p", Target's pricing strategy is designed to remain competitive without positioning itself as either too expensive or inexpensive. Target recognizes that higher-quality products can justify a higher price point while still ensuring affordable options are available for value-conscious shoppers. Pricing transparency is also a priority as scanners are placed across the store so guests can easily verify prices and confirm any discounts without the help of a team member. Clearance items are clearly marked with bright yellow labels and sales are highlighted through noticeable signage throughout the store. By offering a wide assortment of products at varying price levels, Target ensures that every guest can find something that meets their needs, reinforcing its reputation for value and accessibility.

Lastly, "c" for convenience in the EMPAC Model is one of Target's most important strategies. Target carefully selects store locations based on community needs, demographics, and local demand. This often leads to stores being placed in suburban areas with high foot traffic, large parking lots to make guests feel comfortable, and in middle to higher income neighborhoods. Additionally, Target has significantly expanded its online convenience with mobile pickups and shipping orders. Most stores now designate areas for order pickup and drive-up delivery to specialize in this service for guests. If guests don't want to leave their homes, Target offers home delivery where orders arrive within one to two days, with free shipping available on purchases made over \$35, using a Target Circle Card, or through being a 360 member. By combining strategically placed physical locations near the majority of their customer base, Target makes shopping simple and convenient for their guests.

Overall, my experience as a Store Executive Intern at Target was rewarding as it gave me valuable insights into the fast-paced world of retail. Spending time on the sales floor allowed me to build a strong foundation in store operations and guest service, then my final weeks in management gave me the opportunity to strengthen my key skills in forward thinking, adapting to challenges, and maintaining a consumer-focused mindset. This experience not only deepens my understanding of what it takes to run a successful retail store such as Target, but also prepares me to bring these skills into future opportunities. I am truly grateful for my time at Target and excited to apply what I have learned into my senior year and my career post graduation.